

US Patent & Trademark Office

Patent Public Search | Text View

United States Patent	12396436
Kind Code	B1
Date of Patent	August 26, 2025
Inventor(s)	Agans; Christine A.

Cooler for pets

Abstract

A food and beverage cooler for pets includes a cooler housing having a bottom wall and upstanding sidewalls that together define an interior compartment and an open top, the interior compartment being partitioned into two compartments for separate storage of food and water. A first lid portion is pivotally coupled to the cooler housing and is movable between open and closed configurations regulating access to the food and water and having an upper surface defining a pair of food and water bowls. A second lid portion is pivotally coupled atop the first lid portion and is pivotally movable between open and closed configurations, the food and water bowls being accessible only when the second lid portion is at said open configuration. The second lid portion includes a recessed underside into which a zippered pouch is mounted and configured to hold pet toys.

Inventors:	Agans; Christine A. (Camdenton, MO)
Applicant:	Agans; Christine A. (Camdenton, MO)
Family ID:	1000008185573
Appl. No.:	18/910144
Filed:	October 09, 2024

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **A01K5/01** (20060101); **B65D25/04** (20060101); **B65D25/24** (20060101); **B65D25/28** (20060101); **B65D43/16** (20060101); **B65D43/22** (20060101); **B65D51/18** (20060101); **B65D51/28** (20060101); **B65D53/02** (20060101); **B65D81/38** (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **A01K5/0107** (20130101); **B65D25/04** (20130101); **B65D25/24** (20130101); **B65D25/28** (20130101); **B65D43/165** (20130101); **B65D43/22** (20130101); **B65D51/18** (20130101); **B65D51/28** (20130101); **B65D53/02** (20130101); **B65D81/3813** (20130101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC: F25D (3/08)

References Cited

U.S. PATENT DOCUMENTS

Patent No.	Issued Date	Patentee Name	U.S. Cl.	CPC
3395550	12/1967	Dungan	62/464	F25D 3/08
2004/0178208	12/2003	Leba	220/761	F25D 3/08
2018/0149400	12/2017	Valencia	N/A	F25D 3/06
2021/0227787	12/2020	Friedgood	N/A	A45C 13/02

Primary Examiner: Martin; Elizabeth J

Background/Summary

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(1) This invention relates generally to ice chest coolers and, more particularly, to a cooler configured specifically for pets having partitioned compartments for containing food and water, respectively and having a lid whose under surface is configured to define food and beverage bowls, respectively.

(2) Portable pet food coolers have long been an essential accessory for pet owners on the go, offering a means to keep food fresh and water cool during outings or travels. However, traditional designs often fail to meet the diverse needs of pets and their owners. Most pet food coolers feature only a single compartment for storing both food and water. This design forces food and water to share the same space, potentially compromising hygiene and cleanliness. Moreover, the lack of separation can hinder proper organization, especially when both dry food and wet food options are necessary.

(3) Furthermore, pets require a dedicated eating and drinking area separate from food and water storage areas. Unfortunately, pet food coolers make no such provision, forcing pet owners to improvise or carry additional accessories, which can be cumbersome. Pet food coolers also lack storage options for pet-related items such as treats, medicines, and grooming supplies—essentials which must then be carried in separate bags or containers. Together, these shortcomings lower efficiency in packing and storage and increase stress for the pet owner, who must keep mental track of a plethora of items.

(4) Although a few compartmentalized pet food coolers are known in the prior art, they neither incorporate a designated space for eating and drinking nor provide additional storage options for pet-related items. A compartmentalized pet food cooler including these elements would thus constitute an improvement over all prior pet food coolers. Such an invention would be capable of consolidating all essential pet supplies into one convenient unit, streamlining travel plans, and setting a new industry standard in accessibility and functionality for pet owners.

(5) Therefore, it would be desirable to have a food and beverage cooler for pets compartmentalized so as to separately store pet food and water. Further, it would be desirable to have a

compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets incorporating food and water bowls into its design as a designated eating and drinking area for pets. Even further, it would be desirable to have a compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets including a zippered pouch capable of storing smaller pet-related accessories. Also, it would be desirable for this cooler to be insulated and have additional features facilitating ease of transportation.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(6) Accordingly, a food and beverage cooler for pets according to a preferred embodiment of the present invention includes side and bottom walls defining an interior compartment partitioned into two compartments for separate storage of food and water, and a pair of lid portions atop the side walls, which may be coupled to a rear side wall via a hinge and securable in a closed configuration via a latching mechanism. Respective lid portions may further comprise (1) an upper surface defining one or more concave or recessed areas configured to serve as food and water bowls and (2) a zippered pouch configured to hold pet-related articles. The first lid portion and interior compartment may include insulation to maintain the temperature of the pet food and water. The cooler may further include a handle and plurality of wheels to enhance functionality and ease of transportation as subsequently described.

(7) Therefore, a general object of this invention is to provide a compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets capable of separately storing pet food and water.

(8) Another object of this invention is to provide a compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets incorporating food and water bowls into its design, thereby integrating both a food and water storage area and an eating and drinking area into a single device.

(9) Still another object of this invention is to provide a compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets having storage areas for pet-related accessories, thereby combining all essential pet supplies into one convenient unit.

(10) Yet another object of this invention is to provide a compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets that is highly functional and easy to use and transport.

(11) Other objects and advantages of the present invention will become apparent from the following description taken in connection with the accompanying drawings, wherein is set forth by way of illustration and example, embodiments of this invention.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) FIG. 1a is a rear perspective view of the food and beverage cooler for pets according to a preferred embodiment of the present invention.

(2) FIG. 1b is a front perspective view of the food and beverage cooler according to the present invention.

(3) FIG. 2 is another perspective view of the food and beverage cooler for pets as in FIG. 1a, illustrated with the handle in a deployed configuration.

(4) FIG. 3a is a perspective view of the food and beverage cooler for pets as in FIG. 1a, illustrated with a second lid portion and an open configuration.

(5) FIG. 3b is an isolated view of a collapsible bowl according to the present invention illustrated in a collapsed configuration.

(6) FIG. 3c is an isolated view of a collapsible bowl according to the present invention illustrated in an expanded configuration.

(7) FIG. 4 is another perspective view of the food and beverage cooler as in FIG. 3a, illustrated with the zipper pouch shown in an open configuration;

(8) FIG. 5 is another perspective view of the food and beverage cooler as in FIG. 1a, illustrated with the first and second lid portions in open configurations, respectively.

(9) FIG. 6 is an exploded view of the food and beverage cooler as in FIG. 5.

(10) FIG. 7a is a side view of the food and beverage cooler as in FIG. 1a.

(11) FIG. 7b is a sectional view taken along line 7b-7b of FIG. 7a.

DESCRIPTION OF THE PREFERRED EMBODIMENT

(12) A compartmentalized food and beverage cooler for pets according to a preferred embodiment of the present invention will now be described in reference to the accompanying drawings. The food and beverage cooler for pets (referred to as the “cooler”) **100** includes a plurality of exterior walls **10**, a partition **20**, first lid portion **30**, and a second lid portion **35**. The cooler **100** may also include a plurality of wheels **50** and a handle **60**.

(13) More particularly, the exterior walls **10** of the cooler include a bottom wall **11** having a flat configuration suitable for resting on a flat surface and a plurality of side walls **12** extending upwardly and away from the bottom wall **11** (FIG. 1). Together, the bottom and side walls **11**, **12** define an interior compartment **13** (FIG. 5) into which pet food and water may be placed and an open top by which the pet food and water may be accessed. In one embodiment, the side walls **12** have a flat configuration and meet each other at right angles, defining a square or rectangular shaped interior compartment **13**. In another embodiment, the side walls **12** form angles of more or less than 90 degrees or, alternatively, form no discernible angles at all, so as to define an interior compartment **13** that is oval, circular, or non-geometric in shape.

(14) In an important aspect, the partition **20** extends vertically away from the bottom wall **11** in a direction parallel to the plurality of side walls **12** and horizontally away from one of the side walls **12** to an opposite side wall **12**. Thus, the partition **20** divides the interior compartment **13** into two separate compartment portions having similar dimensions and essentially equal volumes, as shown in FIG. 5. The top of the partition **20** is even, or nearly even, with the tops of the side walls **12**. The partition **20** may be made of the same material as the exterior walls **10** and share a unitary construction.

(15) The two compartment portions defined by the partition **20** may include a first compartment portion **21** configured to store pet food and a second compartment portion **22** configured to store water. Preferably, the compartment portions are positioned laterally adjacent one another. More precisely, the two compartment portions **21**, **22** are configured to store a plurality of food containers **23** and water containers **24**, respectively, the plurality of containers **23**, **24** directly holding the pet food and water and one or more ice packs **25** being operative to maintain a desired temperature within the interior area of the cooler **100**. The two compartment portions **21**, **22** and the plurality of containers **23**, **24** are exemplified in FIG. 6. It is understood that the plurality of food and water containers **23**, **24** may be any of the myriad types available on the market. Alternatively, the two compartment portions **21**, **22** may be configured to have pet food and water placed directly into them. In this embodiment, means for selectively draining or dispensing the water in the second compartment portion **22** may be necessary. Thus, one of the side walls **12** of the second compartment portion **22** may define an aperture located adjacent the bottom wall **11** and having dimensions for receiving and securely holding a plug **19** in a friction fit arrangement (i.e. the plug is removably positioned within the aperture to prevent unwanted loss of water). In variations of this embodiment, the plug **19** may be removably connected to the aperture via a snap-on or screw-on arrangement.

(16) Further, the first and second lid portions **30**, **35** are positioned atop the plurality of side walls **12**. A rear edge of the first lid portion **30** is pivotally coupled to an upper rear edge of a corresponding side wall **12**, making the first lid portion **30** pivotally movable between a closed configuration blocking access to the interior compartment **13** and an open configuration allowing access to the interior compartment **13** (see FIG. 1b). An upper rear edge of the second lid portion **35** is pivotally coupled to the rear edge of the first lid portion **30**, making the second lid portion **35** pivotally movable between a closed configuration resting atop the first lid portion **30** and an open configuration displaced from the first lid portion **30**. Means for pivotally coupling together the lid

portions **30**, **35** and the respective side wall **12** may include one or more hinges **33**, which may be of any generic type, size, and material. When both lid portions **30**, **35** are in the closed configuration, they appear to be in a vertically stacked arrangement, the second **35** above the first **30**, with no space between.

(17) Each of the lid portions **30**, **35** comprises a top surface **30a**, **35a** and a bottom surface **30b**, **35b** opposite the top surface **30a**, **35a**, respectively. Preferably, the bottom surface **30b** of the first lid portion **30** includes a raised area or lip **31**, the lip **31** being configured to mate with the partition **20** and plurality of side walls **12** in a friction fit arrangement (i.e. the lip **31** is removably positioned within the open top of the interior compartment **13** as defined by the plurality of side walls **12**). This arrangement is illustrated in FIGS. **5** and **6**. When closed, the bottom surface **30b** of the first lid portion **30** lies flush atop and in contact with the partition **20** and plurality of side walls **12**. Moreover, the lip **31** creates a watertight, and preferably airtight, seal with the partition **20** and plurality of side walls **12** by means of a pair of seal members **31a**. The seal's primary purpose is to prevent spillage during transport, either from the cooler **100** to its exterior environment, or from one of the compartment portions **21**, **22** to the other. The seal may even have a thermal effect, helping maintain the temperature of the pet food and water.

(18) In a critical aspect, the top surface **30a** of the first lid portion **30** defines at least one recessed area **32** having a concave construction and configured to hold a serving of pet food or water. Preferably, the top surface **30a** defines a pair of recessed areas **32** located laterally adjacent one another, at least one of which is configured as a water bowl, and at least one, as a food bowl (FIGS. **3a**, **3b**). It should be noted that these recessed areas **32** may only be accessed as food or water bowls if the first lid portion **30** is in the closed configuration and the second lid portion is in the open configuration. Furthermore, the recessed areas **32** may have a collapsible silicone construction, each recessed area **32** featuring a collapsible sidewall removably positioned within the recessed area **32** itself.

(19) In another critical aspect, the bottom surface **35b** of the second lid portion **35** may define a storage area **36** in which a zippered pouch **37** is mounted, such as by a pair of Velcro or magnetic strips. It is important that the zippered pouch **37** be detachable, should the pet owner wish to clean the storage area **36** and zippered pouch **37** of food and grime. An upper edge of the zippered pouch **37** is operable between an open configuration allowing its contents to be accessed, and a closed configuration prohibiting its contents from being accessed (FIGS. **3a**, **4**). Additionally, the zippered pouch **37** has dimensions suitable for holding pet-related articles such as treats, medicines, and grooming supplies and may be constructed of a clear plastic material so that its contents can be visualized with minimal difficulty or inconvenience.

(20) Further, the lid **30** may include one or more latch mechanisms **40** operable to selectively secure the first and second lid portions **30**, **35** in the closed configuration when actuated. In the preferred embodiment, the one or more latch mechanisms **40** comprise a shaft portion **41** fixedly attached to an edge of the top surface **35a** of the second lid portion **35** and a flange **42** coupled to an end of the shaft **41** opposite the shaft's **41** point of connection with the second lid portion **35**. The flange **42** extends perpendicularly outward and away from the shaft **41** in a direction parallel to a respective side wall **12** (FIGS. **1a**, **2**). As a creative touch, the latch mechanism may even incorporate a fun or themed design, such as the paw of a dog or cat. To actuate the latch mechanism **40**, an edge of both lid portions **30**, **35** and an edge of the respective side wall **12** together define a continuous groove **43** into which the shaft **41** may be removably positioned. When the shaft **41** is thus positioned within the groove **43**, the flange **42** forms a mechanical connection with the respective side wall **12** and prevents the lid portions **30**, **35** from being raised or otherwise removed from the closed configuration. In some embodiments, additional latch mechanisms **40** may be included securing the first and second lid portions **30**, **35** to each other but not to a respective side wall **12**, or securing only the first lid portion **30** to a respective side wall **12** and not the second lid portion **35**. The purpose of such latch mechanisms **40** would be to promote flexibility in the use of

the cooler **100**. Finally, it should be understood that other latch mechanisms **40** may be used besides the one herein described.

(21) Even further, the lid portions **30**, **35** and exterior walls **10** may be constructed of natural or synthetic materials and/or a combination thereof. If plastic is used, the cooler **100** may be constructed in a rotational mold for increased strength and durability. Additionally, the lid portions **30**, **35** and exterior walls **10** may include insulating material **14** to maintain the temperature of the food and water. At a minimum, the insulating material **14** is mounted on at least the bottom surface **30b** of the first lid portion **30** and the interior surfaces of the sidewalls **12**. If more extensive insulation is desirable, the partition **20**, lid portions **30**, **35**, and exterior walls **10** may comprise a shell **15** defining the interior and exterior surfaces of the cooler **100** (see FIG. 7b). The entirety of the shell **15** may have a unitary construction and define a void into which an insulating material **14** may be placed intermediate the interior and exterior of the cooler **100**. Preferably, the insulating material **14** is either Styrofoam or polyurethane, although other materials may suffice.

(22) To facilitate mobility and transportation, the cooler **100** may comprise additional features. Especially in larger, heavier embodiments such as are capable of holding several gallons of food and water, these features may include a plurality of wheels **50** and a handle **60**. In particular, a pair of wheels **50** are operatively mounted to the bottom wall **11** or a rear side wall **12** of the cooler **100**, such as with respective castors **51** that enable wheel rotation (see FIG. 6). It is understood, however, that the wheels in some embodiments may be interconnected with an axle or may alternatively include respective wheel hubs. Moreover, the handle **60** is operatively coupled to a respective side wall **12** via a pair of couplers **61**. Preferably, the handle **60** has a telescopic construction and is movable between a retracted configuration partially recessed within the couplers **61** and the side wall **12** and a deployed configuration extending vertically away from the couplers in a direction parallel to a respective side wall **12** and reaching a height suitable for pulling. The handle **60** may also include an ergonomic grip portion **62**. If desirable, a button may be located within the grip portion **62**, which when actuated, is configured to deploy or retract the handle **60**. In alternative embodiments, the couplers **61** may be configured to allow handle **60** rotation. In such embodiments, the handle **60** is rotatable between a lowered configuration lying flat along the respective side wall **12** and a deployed configuration extending away from the respective side wall **12**.

(23) The disclosure of the present invention is enhanced by harmonizing the accompanying illustrations and claims. The present invention discloses a pair of lid portions that are essentially stacked one atop the other and include length, width, and thickness dimensions that are substantially identical or congruent to one another. More particularly, the first lid portion **30** is an innermost or lowermost portion and having a length and width that defines a generally rectangular geometric configuration that covers a pair of cooler compartments in a sealed friction fit relationship. The first lid portion **30** may define an imaginary horizontal plane and is pivotally coupled to an upper rear edge of the cooler housing, such as with one or more hinges that define a longitudinal axis. Similarly, the second portion **35** is the uppermost or outermost portion that also includes a length, width, and thickness that defines a generally rectangular geometric configuration that is substantially identical to that of the first lid portion **30**, the second lid portion substantially covering an entirety of an upper surface of the first lid portion when resting thereon. The second portion is pivotally coupled to a rear edge of the first portion **30** with hinges that define a longitudinal axis, the respective hinges of respecting lid portions parallel to and displaced atop one another.

(24) In use, the food and beverage containers may be filled and loaded prior to the cooler being transported in a vehicle or being pulled along a sidewalk, walking trail, or road to a destination such as a park for camping area. Then, at a minimum, the lid may be removed to allow access to the container portions, inverted/flipped over and water transferred from the beverage container to the water bowl where it may remain accessible for a period of time or throughout much of a day.

Then, at an expected feeding time, food may be transferred from the food container in the cooler by the food bowl formed in the lid. Later on in the day or even after multiple days of a camping trip, the cooler and any remaining food and water may be pulled or lifted back into a vehicle or pulled along the sidewalk back to the pet owner's car or residence.

(25) It is understood that while certain forms of this invention have been illustrated and described, it is not limited thereto except insofar as such limitations are included in the following claims and allowable functional equivalents thereof.

Claims

1. A food and beverage cooler for pets, comprising: a cooler housing having a bottom wall and a plurality of sidewalls extending upwardly from said bottom wall that collectively define an open top and an interior compartment; a dividing wall separating said interior compartment into a first compartment portion configured to contain pet food and a second compartment portion configured to contain pet water; and a first lid portion having a rear edge pivotally coupled to an upper rear edge of said cooler housing, said first lid portion being pivotally movable between a closed configuration blocking access to said interior compartment and an open configuration allowing access to said interior compartment; a second lid portion having a rear edge pivotally coupled to the rear edge of said first lid portion and is pivotally movable between a closed configuration resting atop an upper surface of said first lid portion and an open configuration displaced from the upper surface of said first lid portion; wherein said first lid portion has a length and a width that defines a rectangular configuration that completely covers the interior compartment at said closed configuration, said first lid portion defining a first horizontal plane; wherein said second lid portion has a length and a width that is at least equal to the length and width of the first lid portion, said second lid portion defining a rectangular configuration that completely covers said upper surface of said first lid portion when positioned at said closed configuration, said second lid portion defining a second horizontal plane that is parallel to and displaced from said first horizontal plane; wherein said upper surface of said first lid portion defines a pair of recessed areas positioned laterally adjacent one another, each having a generally circular and concave configuration adapted configured to hold a single serving of the pet food or of the pet water; wherein said first and second lid portions are pivotally movable between open and closed configurations via hinges, respectively, said respective hinges defining respective longitudinal axes that are situated atop one another at respective closed configurations.

2. The food and beverage cooler of claim 1, wherein said pair of recessed areas are accessible only when said first lid portion is in the closed configuration and said second lid portion is in said open configuration.

3. The food and beverage cooler of claim 1, further comprising a pair of bowls each having a collapsible sidewall removably positioned in each of said pair of recessed areas, respectively.

4. The food and beverage cooler of claim 1, further comprising a zippered pouch detachably mounted to a storage area defined by a bottom surface of said second lid portion, said zippered pouch having an upper edge configured to move between an open configuration allowing access to an interior area and a closed configurations not allowing access to the interior area.

5. The food and beverage cooler of claim 1, further comprising insulation mounted on at least a bottom side of said first lid portion and on at least interior surfaces of said sidewalls of said cooler housing walls so as to maintain a temperature of the water and food.

6. The food and beverage cooler of claim 5 further comprising a pair of seal members mounted to the bottom side of said first lid portion configured to create a watertight seal of said first and second compartment portions when said first lid portion is in said closed configuration.

7. The food and beverage cooler of claim 6, further comprising a latch mechanism fixedly attached at one end to said top surface of said second lid portion and that is operable to selectively secure

said first and second lid portions at said closed configurations, respectively, when actuated.

8. The food and beverage cooler of claim 1, further comprising a plurality of wheels operatively coupled to said bottom wall of said cooler housing and by which the cooler housing is mobile.

9. The food and beverage cooler of claim 8, further comprising a handle coupled to a respective side wall of said cooler housing that is movable between a retracted configuration partially recessed into said respective side wall of said cooler housing and a deployed configuration extending away from said respective side wall for manually pulling the cooler on the ground.

10. A method of using a food and beverage cooler for pets during travel or outdoor activities, comprising: providing a cooler housing having a bottom wall and a plurality of side walls extending upwardly from said bottom wall that, together, define an interior area and an open top, said interior area being divided by a partition into a first compartment portion; placing pet food into said first compartment portion; placing water into said second compartment portion; selectively pivotally operating a first lid portion between a closed configuration blocking access to said interior area and an open configuration allowing access to said interior area, said first lid portion having a rear edge pivotally coupled to an upper rear edge of said cooler housing; selectively pivotally operating a second lid portion between a closed configuration resting atop an upper surface of said first lid portion and an open configuration displaced from the upper surface of said first lid portion, said second lid portion having a rear edge pivotally coupled to the rear edge of said first lid portion; wherein said first lid portion has a length and a width that defines a rectangular configuration that completely covers the interior compartment at said closed configuration, said first lid portion defining a first horizontal plane; wherein said second lid portion has a length and a width that is at least equal to the length and width of the first lid portion, said second lid portion defining a rectangular configuration that completely covers said upper surface of said first lid portion when positioned at said closed configuration, said second lid portion defining a second horizontal plane that is parallel to and displaced from said first horizontal plane; wherein said first and second lid portions are pivotally movable between open and closed configurations via hinges, respectively, said respective hinges defining respective longitudinal axes that are situated atop one another at respective closed configurations; wherein said first lid portion includes an upper surface defining a pair of recessed areas laterally adjacent one another, each recessed area having a circular and concave configuration adapted to hold a single serving of the pet food or of the pet water; wherein said second lid portion has a bottom side that defines at least one recessed area in which a zippered pouch defining an interior area is detachably mounted, said zippered pouch being selectively detachable from the second lid portion for cleaning or for accessing articles stored therein; closing said first lid portion so as to create an insulating seal with said interior area.

11. The method of claim 10, further comprising transporting the cooler housing, said step of transporting the cooler housing including: rolling the cooler on the ground via a plurality of wheels operatively coupled to a bottom surface of said bottom wall; and utilizing a pull-up handle that is coupled to a respective side wall of said cooler housing and that is operably movable between a retracted configuration partially hidden within said respective side wall of said cooler housing and a deployed configuration extending away from said interior area.

12. The method of claim 11, further comprising a latch mechanism operable for selectively securing said second lid portion to said cooler housing during transport so as to prevent spillage of the cooler's contents.

13. The method of claim 10, further comprising insulating at least said first lid portion and said plurality of sidewalls so as to maintain the water and pet food at a predetermined temperature.

14. The method of claim 10, wherein said pair of recessed areas are accessible only when said first lid portion is at said closed configuration and said second lid portion is at said open configuration, respectively.
